



Where's the tech?

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Tricks you should know

If you're a tech geek this is a list of top 10 tricks that you should know by the back of your hand: <http://dgit.in/TechTricks>



Every month we highlight some aspiring tech writers and their spirited attempt to get published in the magazine. Let's have more!

Create your own website visitor counter with PHP & MySQL

Using a third-party tool to count your page views? You don't have to anymore. Create a personalised counter and code it with this guide



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You've probably tried Google Analytics or another service to track the amount of views that your website attracts. While either service is indeed the best option to go with, creating things on your own is always more exciting, no matter how many mistakes are made along the way. Coding a visitor counter is relatively easy if you have the right resources. We're assuming

here that you've used PHP and MySQL, at least till the level of "Hello World!" You'll also need to install a popular PHP development environment called 'XAMPP' for Windows or 'MAMP' for Mac. But, of course, if you've already purchased a hosting server online, then you can use that instead.

Before we work on the code, let's familiarise ourselves with what exactly we'll be building and the flow of the program. The whole code is written in a single file that we'll name "index.php". When the user visits your website, say, www.your-website.com, "index.php" will load and display the user's IP address. It could look something like this: "Hello 127.0.0.1". This would be followed by "This page has been seen yyyy times by xxxx different people on earth." We'll be storing two different things in our database: the IP address of the visitor (so that we can know the number of unique visitors to the site) and the frequency of page views by the same IP address. "Page Views" (yyyy) and "Visitors" (xxxx) are different terms, so don't mix them up.

Let's begin by creating a database

The first thing we're going to do is create a database in MySQL and call it "visitors". Using "phpMyAdmin", open up this "visitors" database and run the SQL code found in this pastebin paste: <http://dgit.in/DatabaseCreation> to create the tables in your database.

The SQL code given in the pastebin paste will create a table named "visit" and include three columns in it. The first column is for "ID" with "Auto_Increment" property. The second column is for "ip_address", which we'll use to store the IP addresses of each site user. And the third column is for "visit_count" – this is for unique visitors to your website who visit more than once. Each time this user stops by, the value in this column is incremented by 1.

We're now done with the database, all we need to work on is the code. We'll be taking each part of the code (in series) and explaining them. Your task is simply to understand and write them all in a single .php file.

Adding the <head> tag

Here, we're firstly beginning the HTML code by opening PHP under the <head> tag. Next we're going to connect with the MySQL Database. You can change the details as required. This will probably be the password and the database name, if you plan on using a name other than "visitors". Lines 4 and 5 are used to connect with the database as per the information given in lines 1, 2, 3 and 4. Then, using the <title> tag we'll define the page's title and be done with the head part. You can check out the code for this part on this pastebin paste: <http://dgit.in/AddingHead>

Moving on to the <body>

```
<body>
<?php
$user_ip = $_SERVER['REMOTE_ADDR']; //6
echo "Hello $user_ip"; //7
```

Let's open up the "body" tag and inside it, we'll open another "php" tag. The 6th line is declaring a variable "\$user_ip" which will hold the user's IP address by using the "\$_SERVER['REMOTE_ADDR'];" function.

Note: Line 7 is optional. We've simply added it to check whether we're getting the correct IP address. If you're using a local server (XAMPP), then you won't be able to get your real external IP address and this is where the local servers fail. To overcome this problem, you may want to try the same with a remote-online-server. To get one for free, head over to neq3.com or heliohost.org. If you can afford to buy, then go with Bigrock or Hostgator's Linux plans.

Store the User's IP address, page views and visitor count

Find the code for doing it on this pastebin paste: <http://dgit.in/StoringUserIP>. This code is the most important one, as it's responsible for storing the user's IP address along with the number of page views by that IP address. We're using the